

The Heart Under the Hill

Tuesday, 18 August 2026 · plot and bookkeeping: what changed, what is canon, rulings, threads, quotes

The GM's record of the session, spoiler-tolerant: the companion to the player recap. Nothing here was shown to the players.

GM-only. Never surface any of this in `recap.html` or the Session Diary page.

1 • Where the campaign now stands

Shards: 1 / 4. The party holds **The Graveheart**, in the party stash (not attuned, no attunement needed). This is the first milestone — **level-up to 5 is due**.

They are still underground. The session ended in room 05 (Hollow's Heart) immediately after the vision. Stated intent: leave and get back to camp. Session 5 has to resolve the walk out — decide now whether the Hollow restocks (the DM raised the question in play and left it open).

Selma never happened. The party went straight from the Kestrel camp to the shrine and never re-entered Greenrest. The Selma scene, the potion restock, and Warin's half-cashed barracks whisper all carry forward untouched. The potion economy is now genuinely dry — this matters.

Reveal-dream timing ⚠

Per the plot doc, **a reveal dream OPENS a session, never closes one**, and the party has exactly the prerequisite now (1 shard). **Session 5 must open cold with Appendix A.1 — "she is asleep • warmth"** — before shopping, before the recap, before anything. Dress it in the day's trace: *a warm red stone in a dead hand that will not open*.

One wrinkle: **they will be sleeping rough in the forest or in a dungeon**, not in Greenrest. Decide whether A.1 fires wherever they sleep (recommended — the shard is the trigger now, not the town) or waits for a bed. Also note **nobody drank tonic tonight**, so nothing blocks it.

The gray tree

Per §5.3/§5.4, one shard held should show the gray tree **its first green in living memory**, and the square should talk of nothing else. The party is not in town to see it — so the *town* discovers it first. That is a gift: they walk back into a Greenrest that is already buzzing about something they caused and don't know they caused.

2 • Bookkeeping to apply to the live world

- ☐ **Milestone level-up: all four PCs to level 5.** Big jump — Extra Attack for Thomas and Morgash, 3rd-level spells for Gren, Jetten's extra Hunter's Mark use (he asked about this at the table and the DM confirmed the chart: 2 uses at 1–4, **3 at 5–8**).
- ☐ **Hollowed effects are still live on three sheets** — Gren (–3), Thomas (–20), Morgash (–5). Gren's in-world ruling (Religion 18) was that **a full night's rest in a real bed** clears them. Decide and apply: does a long rest in the forest clear it, or must it be Greenrest? Whatever you rule, the Clear Hollowed macro (hotbar slot 7) is the lever, and it posts a public receipt — let the table watch it come back.
- ☐ **Combat state left on sheets:** Concentrating: Bless / Blessed (42s remaining) on all four, Divine Favor on Thomas, Bloodied on Morgash, Mage Armor on Gren. Clean these up before session 5 or they'll expire weirdly mid-scene.
- ☐ **Jetten's ranger slots read 3/3** on the live sheet despite him being out at the table. Either the DM refunded them or a short-rest interaction misfired — verify before session 5.
- ☐ **Jetten's Arrows are at quantity 0** (ordinary), 17 × +1 remaining. He is going to run dry.
- ☐ **Party gold is 7pp / 9gp.** They spent nearly everything at the Full Larder last session and found no coin in the Hollow. A restock scene at Selma's will be constrained — that is fine and interesting, but be ready for them to want to sell the **3 × Necrotic Sword** and **3 × Kestrel Company Lockets**.
- ☐ **The lockets are Kestrel property.** Three of them now. Returning them to Daggerford (or to whoever hired the Kestrels) is a live, unprompted hook the party has not noticed yet.

3 · Loose threads

New tonight

1. **The Graveheart's vision is the only bridge from this site to her.** It fired correctly and the party read it correctly. They have not yet said "the tree in the square" out loud in connection with it — but they will. Let them.
2. **"One chamber of a heart — and a heart has four."** This hint has *not* been delivered yet. Hold it for when someone examines the shard properly (the item description carries it).
3. **⚠ The shard tax was not recited at the lift.** The planted payload — *crystal · obviously still a heart · warm · it beats · it never takes a mark* — did not get said when Jetten picked it up; the vision carried the moment instead. **Hesper delivered two thirds of it early** in her origin story ("*warm, beating, the size of two cupped hands*"), which is arguably better placement. Say the full four beats next time anyone handles it, and at every subsequent shard.
4. **Hesper killed the party's Greenrest theory without them noticing.** She dated herself at 300–500 years and never mentioned the town — but **nobody asked her the word "Greenrest."** The planned kill-shot beat ("*I don't know that word*") did not fire. It is still available: the lockets, the Necrotic Swords, or simple reflection can bring them back to it. Do not force it.
5. **Nobody has connected "three greedy treasure hunters found a warm beating shard in a cave" to "there are three more shards out there."** When they do, the four ruins stop being a menu and start being a countdown.
6. **The faceless, handless statue** appeared twice (rooms 01 and 05) and Thomas correctly read it as pre-theological and self-invented. He asked "*would it be pre-human?*" and got a partial answer. This is good, load-bearing texture — the shrine genuinely has nothing to do with the Dreamer, and the party has now confirmed that with their own checks.
7. **Gren's Everseed Acorn** got its first real airing — "*I still have not found the place where I belong.*" Greenrest is the obvious answer the campaign is dangling. Note that the finale kills the valley. That is a knife worth keeping sharp.
8. **Robert's fear that Morgash would turn into a wight** was genuine and drove real decisions (no long rest in the tomb). The mechanics don't support it — Life-Drain kills raise **zombies**, and only Hesper made wights, from living captives — but the party doesn't know that and the tension was excellent. Consider never correcting it directly.
9. **Scheduling:** Drew flies to Madrid on **Tuesday 1 September** (taking his stepson to a semester abroad) — he is on a plane that night. He offered to have someone run Jetten, or to move the session to a Monday. **He is fine for Tuesday 25 August.** Sort this by email.

Carried forward, untouched

1. **Selma** — the conversation, the potion restock, and the tonic's real explanation.
2. **Warin Holt's whisper** — the barracks side-channel, away from Oswin.
3. **Jetten's moonstone necklace** — still unexplained, still unasked-about.
4. **Morgash withheld Lae'zel** from the party. Tom needled Anthony about it in play tonight ("*maybe then Lae'zel would love you*") — table banter, but the asymmetry is intact.
5. **Marn's Journal and Sera's Map** are now fully read and used. The map is doing exactly the job it was built for.
6. Cold: the escaped will-o'-wisp (Gren's vendetta), the escaped displacer beast, the unread Traveller's Letter, the fey temple's thin place, Pip.

4 • Rules and table issues to fix

- **Combat automation was a clear win.** Multiple unprompted compliments; combat moved much faster than session 3. The DM has "a bunch of notes for things to fix" — capture them.
- **Bugs seen in play:**
 - Shield Master's bash offered itself against a creature that was already dead.
 - Topple prompted on an already-prone target.
 - Weapon-mastery Vex/Slow prompts fire but nothing applies the benefit — the player must claim it in the roll dialog, and everyone forgot at least once.
 - Gren's **Wand of the War Mage +1** did not appear to be applying its +1 to spell attack rolls even when equipped and attuned; Tom re-equipped and re-attuned with no change. **Investigate.**
 - Innate Sorcery's save-DC bump did not show in effects; Tom had to re-target himself.
 - A stray "map artifact" token appeared in room 03 and had to be explained away.
 - The combat carousel position drew complaints — the DM wants a Baldur's-Gate-style single row.
- **Rules clarified at the table** (worth a player-patch-notes line): weapon mastery is free and stacks multiple masteries per turn; Bless should go on the attackers and on the caster (for concentration); Divine Smite is a bonus action in 2024 and cannot ride a crit; smite and Lay on Hands compete for the same bonus action; sorcery points return on a short rest (half sorcerer level, once per long rest); hit dice return at half maximum on a long rest.
- **Long-rest-in-a-dungeon ruling** was made on the fly and was the right call. Write it down.

5 • Quotes of the night

"You know, I thought you would be interesting, but your insolence irritates me. You will not make a suitable wight — you'll make an excellent zombie." — **Osric, the Keeper**, declining the parley

"I am Hesper. I will answer plainly. No need for riddles, no need for bargaining. To be honest, I haven't even talked to anyone in a very long time." — **Hesper, the Mortician**

"We saw it; we couldn't put it down... And so we stood with the Graveheart — lonely — but it gave us life." — **Hesper**, five hundred years of it in one sentence

"But I'm tired. I don't want to do this anymore." — **Hesper**, asking

"You should have talked to us, Osric." — **Thomas A. Invictus** (Robert), mid-beheading

"I don't like this guy, so I'm going to chop his head off." — **Thomas**, on method

"Let the dead lie." — **Jetten Elisedil** (Drew), closing the last empty coffin

"I still have not found the place where I belong." — **Gren Greenmantle** (Tom), on the Everseed Acorn

"That was useless. They never give you any information." — **Gren**, on squirrels, after bribing one with a week of rations

"I'd be afraid of having an orc that turns into a wight." — **Robert**, arguing against resting in the tomb

"It's here, guarded by Cadoc, waiting for the next body to be prepared as a wight to keep us company." — **Hesper**, stating the dungeon's thesis out loud

GM-only. Compiled from the transcript, the chat log and the live sheets by the session scribe.